one dedicated not to mere ornamentation, but to a "present utopia," a Venetian allegory *sui generis.* To ward off the lasting effects of a purely Romantic afterimage, however, it would be necessary to consider other views of the city—say, the observations of a merchant from Singapore who visited here in the fourteenth century. Even an irreverent or uncanny, surrealistically reassembled view sometimes proves helpful—where the palaces are imagined to turn into wax figures, for example, or the facade of the Basilica di San Marco is transformed into a gigantic music box from a nineteenth-century fairground of childhood memory. What sort of music would blare forth when the church facade began to play? Certainly not music from the period of the church's builders, and certainly not the music of the "Liebestod," whose composer died here, and whose "endlessly indistinct essence" captures, bewitches, and illuminates the deathly beauty of Venice even today. In the end, the music box remains identical to the Italian night that, although permanently indebted to Romanticism, is most indigenous to Venice. Yet through Romanticism—daytime moonlight, the Byzantine mosaic-lamp between curtains, blossoming wax-music, and the eternal return's music of hanging gardens and palaces (to be sung on the water)—Venice has arrived at a new phase of its ripening, albeit still in proximity to an Orient that never was. Steeped in the past and yet unconsummated, the city lies on the sea route leading to that fanciful Orient. Venice is magnificent as any evening-light that ever glimmered in the sky; it demonstrates that, now as ever, there exists no viable poetry without a dash of Italian night.

1934

Italy and Porosity

One travels to this country mostly in the wrong way. Taking along expectations and images that are unfounded, or at least one-sided. Consequently, one's eyes remain closed to many things in Italian life. Whatever does not conform to the view inculcated by schools and conventional education is made invisible. But in the South, something other than clear measure is thriving—something, indeed, that does not greatly value such measure. Not only the human animal, flourishing there so colorfully, stands in the way of Goethe's "noble simplicity and quiet greatness": even

that which Goethe saw, and which has been preserved up to today, resists compliance with the standards of the North. Not every object in Italy possesses a form as stable and beautifully defined as that of an antique statue. Similarly, Walter Benjamin has described Italy as "porous," implying not a classical but a baroque interplay: an object that lacks boundaries, but that is nonetheless bound together.

Even the wines in Italy seem to slip between the characteristics of a fruit juice and a flower. Even the better households serve potatoes, vegetables, and roast on the same platter, with a nameless sauce ladled over everything. The people do not sleep or wake during separate intervals, reserving the night for one, and the day for the other; instead, the day is as permeated by sleep as the night is by waking. Furthermore, even the common man takes part in high fashion, dressing up in formal black for the evening, while the man of refinement uses a knife for eating, so that evening dress is mixed with folk customs and vice versa. There is almost no one who is "truly" mature or "truly" childlike; the children are already very purposeful in their endeavors, even money-hungry and calculating, while the adults in turn are open and uninhibited, easily swayed by suggestion and circumstance, given to singing or playing what are almost children's games in the village square. A great many Italians display *cuore* [heart] in the best sense of the word; nevertheless, even this ground is unstable and liable to change: for every forty people there is already one lawyer, and the craftiness, the will to defraud are not just legends. The honoring of outward form, moreover, means keeping a certain distance; nevertheless, it isn't only the Neapolitan people who want to warm one another with a special sense of presence and closeness. To see a party of Neapolitans enter a restaurant and spread out over the tables, even the already partly occupied ones, and to observe the initiation of social contact and the mingling of conversations, is a true lesson in porosity. There is nothing aggressive in this, nothing like the German practice of confiscation; rather, everything is friendly and open: a diffuse, collective mode of gliding. Privacy and the demarcation of personal space remain universally almost incomprehensible; thus the desire for separate bedrooms is, even today, incommensurable with the Italian concept of marriage as a pact of coalescence as well as a public institution. The language, and particularly the formation of vowels, is likewise open on all sides, resonant and fluent, made for the open air and for catching one's attention. No man stands there with the rough-hewn skin of a stone column, all by himself like an

antique statue. Rather, groups of men gather in baroque patterns of verbal discharge and overflow; rapid gestures enable even further discharges of a word's meaning, and soon the dialogue becomes a choir. Speech pours out, as if from the mouths of figures in a fountain; the vowels are imbued with a metal like the color of confectionery foil, like the green, golden, and blue mineral ores used in Italian fireworks, that most beloved of spectacles, that most basic manifestation of streaming splendor.

The typical house is not constructed in accordance with a fixed plan specifically designed for it, but grows room after room in an almost careless fashion, in such a way that additional rooms could always be built above, or preferably next to, the existing ones. The extensive width of most Italian houses is explained by this, and not by any classical affinity for the horizontal. A completely different type of residential plan can be seen in Pompeii, where private space is emphasized by means of a vertical, rather than a horizontal, layout. Indeed, even the Renaissance palaces are not constructed according to a proper plan, and don't reveal the faultless symmetry that has been simulated in isolated photographs. Interiors of middle-class homes show hardly any sense of solid, attractive habitability; instead, the placement of furniture within a room is arbitrary and changeable as the scenes in the street. The residential interior participates in the exterior world: the result is a merging of private and public space. Thus, the door that opens onto the street (or onto a tiny balcony) often serves as the dwelling's sole window as well. The light source consequently is not a part of the wall, helping to enclose space; rather, it is the street's way of intervening within the dwelling, of pressing inward with the force of light. Conversely, the world outside has many of the features of a living room—especially in the piazzas (even the newer ones) that are almost entirely, but beautifully, closed in. Italy has a surfeit of such roofless banqueting halls or dance halls, from the piazza in Capri to Piazza San Marco in Venice; yet they possess a sense of enclosed interiority that is often absent in the inner rooms of residences. If, by this simple reversal of inside and outside, one believes that (here, at least) the principle of porosity has been circumvented, then the street life of Naples shows how easily an Italian town can get along without a piazza, and how powerfully the disorder of the Italian domicile spills over into the streets. Here, at evening, goats are herded down the main avenue, which is already wracked with the noise of a world metropolis; cows are even milked at the curbside. Close by, a late-model bus rushes past, only to slow and si-

dle around an illustrious *pompe funèbre* with fancy glass carriages, a hearse excessively decorated with flowers and wood carvings, marchers costumed as the Grim Reaper, others carrying the Crown of Eternal Life, a hundred priests, musicians in hyacinth-colored robes, weeping women, and with extra space available for onlookers to join in the procession: all the attributes of the baroque era. One can see artists painting pictures on the sidewalk with colored chalk; the virtuosos are applauded, collect their money, and after a few minutes the Red Indian in feather headdress or the heavenly Jerusalem are once more trampled underfoot: painting as a mode of gliding, without need of a frame, like street music. Even serious art such as the theater is nowhere closed upon itself. In the theater, people smoke, come and go without a care; conversation and social life play on in the balconies even during the performance; cries of dissatisfaction or "*Daccapo!*" [Play it again!] freely interrupt, turning the audience into the supporting actors in the piece, and the actors themselves very often into "porous" protagonists on stage. This manner of eliding near and far, of gliding between unscrupulous seduction and insular paradox, between theater and church, is at the same time a characteristic of Italian Catholicism and, by extension, of global Catholicism. The ringing of church bells is both a pretty noise and a call to prayer; waxen Madonna figures are contained in glass shrines that are illuminated at night. Here, the annual fair seeks its rendezvous with sacred mystery; indeed, the profane and the sacred prove to be innocently interchangeable. The procession of St. Rosalia in Palermo achieves the utmost in conjoining these two powers, but the Neapolitan evening processions during Advent give a comparable picture of whirling activity. Policemen carry the Madonna, who is dressed as a bride and standing upright, in a sort of canopy bed; upon the canopy there is a red velvet heart, and on the heart, a word embroidered in gold letters: *AMORE.* And all the young people pursue their amorous games under the protection of this divine doll, spreading the joy of the conjugal chamber along with that of the Holy Night. The confusion or meshing of generations and time periods, classes and myths is especially bewildering in Naples: young women in the flower of their youth are seen in the company of old women with long noses and eyeglasses, ugly as Phorcyads[54] or as witches at the stake, but possessed of dignified and pious bearing; then again, there is the church on the Piazza del Mercato, crowded with beggars, sick people, and cries of entreaty addressed to wholly unknown gods as well as to the Virgin Mary—all this under the

pompous facade of the church, heavily decorated with Spanish gold, which was erected for the benefit of the highest circles of the Christian community, and which still serves as a constant reminder of their status. Or at the cathedral of Amalfi, where the apostle Andrew lies buried, on the night of St. Andrew itself: a rapid procession sweeps through the church, the bronze statue of the apostle held high, as torches and candles fantastically illuminate the scene; the statue is then carried to the door, so that it can exert its miracle-working power on all the people in the piazza. There it is greeted by a drumroll, but also by a rococo song, trite and merry, sung in unison by the crowd in the midst of this strange Tibetan night procession. The rhythm of street ballads and sublime melodies, barrel organs and grand emotions: this is very often the form taken by Italian music, which culminates in the nineteenth century with Verdi's operas up to *Aida*. The halting death theme in *Il trovatore*, with Manrico's warbling song "O Leonora" in the middle, contains just as much porous juxtaposition and bazaar-like all-inclusiveness as the procession of the apostle, with just as much undivided, even indeterminate *duttilità* [suppleness]. Pirandello's dramatic technique, among others, falls in this category: here too, things and people have no boundaries; the most diverse spheres intersect one another, consciously porous this time. It is no accident, then, that De Chirico, who works in Rome (painting smokestacks in a primeval forest lapped by an ocean wave) is most skilled in the art of montage.

Those who come from the North would rather not see all this. They seek, in contrast to the gloom of their native land, a completely clear form of life, closed at every point. Far too few travel to Italy *from the South*, unfurling the map starting from Palermo, or even better from Tunis and its souks: here, the facile and wholly subjective contrast to the North's lack of form is left behind. Goethe's strict insistence on a classical Italy and his almost clinically correct will to contrast have won acceptance, yet it was Goethe himself who imparted the following bit of advice, which went unheeded: "Italy without Sicily makes no impression in the soul; here is the key to everything." In southern Italy, this late, non-classical, Orient-saturated culture of the Mediterranean can be felt most intensely, along with the way it has flooded the art and people of Italy as a whole. From the vantage point of Arabia and the Norman court,[55] it is easier to understand the crooked, narrow streets, the town criers' music, the watchtowers, the minarets as *campanili*, the polychromatic carpet-domes, even the most

authentically Italian aspects of the high-northern city of Verona—so that Florence, previously the rule, now becomes the exception. Even today, however, Neapolitan folk life is just as vexing to Baedeker as the fountain basin [shaped like a sinking ship] in front of the Spanish Steps in Rome, or the "tasteless" tabernacle of Bernini in St. Peter's Cathedral. Nonetheless, a new style of painting today has developed a feeling for juxtaposition, indeed, for *omnia ubique* [everything everywhere]: a not only classical attitude toward the dignity of other cultures magnificently brought together in Italy. Yet what about the Renaissance? Did it truly occasion the rebirth of antiquity, at least as a will to art and culture? In southern Italy, the influence of the Renaissance can hardly be detected—here, it almost immediately turned into the Spanish baroque, while the Arabic background remained. In northern Italy, much that is deemed to be a continuation of the classical tradition, which in fact hindered the reception of Gothicism in this region, actually belongs to an Arabic-Byzantine tradition supplemented with classical elements. The Renaissance, of course, played with all manner of classical construction codes pertaining to columns, pilasters, gables, and facades, and to this extent it dampened the quickly ensuing eruption of the baroque's entangled lines. But the Arabic dream-glow, the Byzantine arch, and the Byzantine (pointed) cupola remained stronger than any classical elements. And the baroque, once its breakthrough was achieved, worked especially well within this tradition (to the horror of the classicists), inasmuch as it could effortlessly assimilate the forms of the Orient from Stamboul to Siam.

And from this vantage point, too, the tendencies toward porosity may be better understood. They are stronger in Italy than anywhere else, precisely where one expects to see mostly statuesque figures. In looking for the cause of this flowing and mixing quality, one is perhaps likely to think of the Italian sunshine and the open air; these in turn are supposed to explain what stands in the way of classical form. But the Greeks and the Romans shared the same sunshine, which ought to have helped sharpen, not diminish, contours. Indeed, the atmospheric light of northern Europe seems far better suited to porosity. Yet the situation is reversed: the North is the home of separateness, of the clear (bourgeois) facade, of measured proportion. What could be more precisely opposed to porosity? These attributes of the North proceed from piecework, rather than from a still unified and wholistic kind of activity; they derive from the capitalistic division of labor and its corresponding mathematically jointed mode of un-

derstanding, rather than from a feeling for characteristic form developing through its own vitality. In short, the bourgeoisie and its culture stand in opposition to porosity; as such, they find themselves especially at home in the Renaissance of northern Europe. The Italian Renaissance, whose bourgeois mandate was quickly interrupted by Hispanization and the Counter-Reformation, is defined (as we have seen) much more by the deviation of Arabic-Byzantine medievalism into the baroque than by the rebirth of antiquity. *Moorish art (never completely vanquished) and the baroque are, even today, still the most powerful determinants of Italian culture.* Both, however, are constitutive of porosity; both emanate from a will to fullness and wholeness that is but erroneously sought in antiquity. The Orient today still knows the art of merging and linking all of life's expressions, written characters, lifelines, and arabesques—how these lead from home to the workplace, the market, and the mosque, from one to the All, and from the All again to any given point along the way. The baroque, for its part, aims in a different fashion—but with the same anti-classical intent—at the overflow, the *espressivo*, the transparency of every phenomenon and at the reflective power of every monad to represent and contain the universe. This baroque is not necessarily equivalent to "formlessness." Rather, it brings forth a different, perhaps deeper form—one, at least, from which nothing chaotic has been excluded (as it has in classical art)—a form in which *duttilità* is sought, with the strange and unusual as its spices and with an abundance of oblique allegories. From this perspective, it makes sense to consider Jean Paul as the last baroque poet, as well as the most colorful interpreter of a non-classically viewed Italy.

Even in the South, only vestiges of this tradition are found today. Porosity is, in the end, no more than the severely attenuated manifestation of a still-glowing source of heat. Here, even the glow of the baroque itself often did not overcome chaos, but simply allowed its entry, so that it appears diffuse, overly "organic," and bombastic. But classical form never once engaged in a full-blown battle with life, and much less did its temple prevail over barbarism. For this reason, chaos in antiquity appears to be unsurmounted. Yet it presents itself not as sheer bombast, but as sheer elision, as something to be averted, so that the anxiously noble facades seem to be on the defensive against it—hardly the pose of a victor. In any case, the Italian essence can still be traced to Bernini's statues, to the stirring and exchanging *duttilità* of the Jesuit style. If a valid project can be discerned in all this overflowing as well as collecting activity, then it is that

many things of both an intimidating and a commemorative character remain to be discovered about the *problem* of porosity in Italy, insofar as it renders the universal in the particular, and exchanges—*andata e ritorno* between the *merceria* [sundries shop] through the bell tower to the Piazza San Marco—interpenetrating spheres.

1925

The Empire of Syagrius

Historical maps occasionally seem quite up to date. Upon one such map, entitled "Europe during the Era of the Migration of Peoples," there is, amid the newly founded barbarian nations, an enclave that bears the legend "Empire of Syagrius." A Roman name, linguistically familiar to students, that nonetheless appears surprisingly misplaced in this time and circumstance. The whole length of the Seine flows through it; Paris, already no longer called Lutetia, marks its center. The accompanying text reads "Syagrius, last Roman governor of Gaul, who from 461 administered the last vestige of Roman dominion, a northwestern region with Soissons as its capital. Syagrius ruled like an independent prince; after the death of his father Aegidius in 464, he inherited the area shown here and retained possession of it until 486, when he was defeated near Soissons by the Frankish king Clovis. The Roman dominion in Gaul, the last part of the western Roman Empire, thereby came to an end." A school memory with an enduring and somewhat magical quality. The Île-de-France, which once represented the last vestige of Roman antiquity in the world, is now the island of a quieter, sometimes still genteel-seeming capitalism.

Thus, in entering into this space, one also travels backward in time. Into an era that once prevailed in our own nation as well, at least as far as money is concerned. When commercial activity still flourished, and the honest businessman raised his children to the same trade. This is still self-evident over there; one needn't listen twice to what another says, namely, to what the other is saying and also to how the other is scheming to defraud one. The path is not yet crooked, heading neither downward nor very boldly upward. Life is still halfway smooth; most people get along quite well.

Not as if ordinary cares are absent, but they are ordinary. The thrifty